FIVE INNOVATIVE PERIOD PRODUCTS YOU CAN BUY

1. MENSTRUAL CUP STERILISER

Company: SIRONA

Approx. price: ₹1,299

A portable electric steriliser that cleans a menstrual cup in about a minute using steam. It doubles up as a storage case, making reusable cups easier to maintain while travelling

2. DISPOSABLE PERIOD PANTIES

Company: PEE SAFE

Approx. price: ₹399 (PACK OF TWO)

Looks like regular underwear but is designed for heavy-flow days, overnight use, travel or postpartum recovery

3. RASH-FREE COTTON PADS

Company: PLUSH

Approx. price: ₹299-399

Made with a 100% American cotton top-sheet instead of a synthetic layer to reduce friction, rashes and irritation

4. PERIOD PAIN RELIEF PATCH

Company: SIRONA

Approx. price: ₹249 (PACK OF FIVE)

A stick-on heating patch worn under clothing that provides gentle warmth for menstrual cramps without needing electricity or hot-water bags

5. MENSTRUAL DISC

Company: NUA

Approx. price: ₹1,499

Unlike a menstrual cup, the disc sits higher behind the pubic bone rather than lower in the vaginal canal. It can hold more fluid, often be worn for up to 12 hours and is preferred by some users for sport or travel

Deep Bajaj says, "The conversation just got too loud to suppress."

Dr Ghosh welcomes the change. "The expansion of menstrual products recognises that women's needs are different," she says. "A schoolgoing teenager, an athlete, a working professional and a new mother may all need different solutions."

BEYOND THE PRODUCT

Doctors say the biggest challenge now is not access to products but making an informed choice. "Marketing claims and social media may create pressure to switch products, even if they are unsuitable for an individual," adds Dr Ghosh. Proper menstrual routines, like changing products on time, maintaining intimate hygiene and disposing of used products properly are important, according to Dr Indra Nedumaran, senior gynaecologist and obstetrician, VS Hospitals, Chennai. She cautions against overusing intimate washes or antiseptic products during periods, saying, "They can kill the good bacteria that protect the vagina. For most women, soap and water are enough."

> **"Awareness has improved significantly, but many girls, particularly in rural areas, still face misinformation, stigma and limited access to menstrual products and sanitation facilities"**



DR LIPI SHARMA, *Consultant, Obstetrics and Gynaecology, ShardaCare-HealthCity, Greater Noida*

Wearing a pad for too long or not cleaning reusable products can increase the risk of rashes, fungal and bacterial infections and, in some cases, urinary or reproductive tract infections. A 2015 study published in *PLOS One* found an association between menstrual hygiene practices and urogenital symptoms among women in Odisha. A 2018 study in *BMC Infectious Diseases* linked poor menstrual hygiene with lower reproductive tract infections.

"Awareness, too, is key. Parents should start talking about menstruation when they notice the first signs of puberty, not after the first period," says Dr Nedumaran. "Preparing a girl helps her cope with puberty with confidence instead of fear." She recommends that girls who have just started menstruating begin with sanitary pads or period panties, and explore menstrual cups and tampons later.

There is still a long way to go. "Awareness has improved significantly, but many girls, particularly in rural areas, still face misinformation, stigma and limited access to menstrual products and sanitation facilities," says Dr Sharma. Access must increase so no girl in India has to muster courage before asking for a pad. ■